

General Business Grants & Funding

Free money for your business is rare but real — and there are many low-cost loans and funding paths too. Below are the main national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

True “free grant” money is competitive and limited — and the SBA itself does NOT give grants to start a typical business. Be very skeptical of anyone guaranteeing you a government grant for a fee; that's the #1 small-business scam.

1 Search Real Federal Grants

The official hub for all federal grant programs — mostly for research, nonprofits, and specific sectors.

☐ Grants.gov

The official database of 1,000+ federal grant programs. Search and apply for free.

→ www.grants.gov

☐ SBA — Funding Programs

SBA's honest overview of grants, loans, and investment — and who actually qualifies.

→ www.sba.gov/funding-programs

2 Research & Innovation Grants

The biggest federal grants go to businesses developing new technology.

☐ SBIR / STTR

Federal R&D grants for innovative small businesses. Note: authorization was pending renewal in early 2026 — check the site for current status.

→ www.sbir.gov

3 Low-Cost Loans Instead of Grants

If grants don't fit, these affordable loans often do.

☐ SBA Microloans (up to \$50,000)

Small loans through nonprofit lenders, designed for startups and underserved owners.

→ www.sba.gov/funding-programs/loans/microloans

☐ SBA Loan Finder (Lender Match)

Get matched with SBA-approved lenders for larger loans.

→ www.sba.gov/funding-programs/loans/lender-match

☐ CDFIs — Community Lenders

Mission-driven lenders with flexible terms for underserved entrepreneurs.

→ www.cdfifund.gov/programs-training/certification/cdfi

4 Private & Corporate Grants

Companies and foundations run grant programs too — smaller but real.

☐ Corporate Small Business Grants

Programs from companies and foundations (amounts and deadlines vary). See the Foundations & Corporate Grants guide for specifics.

→ See: **Foundations & Corporate Grants guide**

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

If anyone “guarantees” a government grant, asks for a fee to apply, or says you’ve been “pre-approved” for free government money — it’s a scam. Real federal grants are applied for free at Grants.gov.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Don’t overlook SBA microloans and CDFIs — for most new businesses, an affordable loan is far more realistic than a grant, and the application help is free.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national starting points. For grants and lenders specific to your state, industry, or situation, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we’ll help you find them.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
